

CDN Incident Alert: 0100. TLP: CLEAR**Date****Title** MD False allegations about NATO countries planning to send troops to Moldova and Ukraine spread online

02/10/2025

Summary

- In mid-September 2025 various sources claimed that NATO countries are ready to deploy troops to Moldova and Ukraine to invade Transnistria.
- This incident may potentially harm the electoral process in Moldova and sow panic in the country for the fear of a war scenario.
- The main narrative claims NATO countries have an aggressive agenda and intend to occupy Transnistria and control Moldova militarily.
- The campaign was spread across multiple platforms including social media and news websites in multiple languages.
- The campaign aimed to spread hate to Western countries, polarise, and intimidate Moldovan society and to smear NATO.
- Recommendations include removing fake content and taking down inauthentic accounts, debunking the allegations of imminent military operations, and promoting a joint NATO-EU strategic communications (StratCom) plan towards Moldova.

Incident

In mid-September 2025 pro-Russian X troll accounts, Telegram channels, and media outlets started spreading the news of an imminent military operation to be conducted in Moldova by NATO troops from Romania, France, and the United Kingdom, with the goal to occupy Transnistria. The first of such actions was observed on September 10 when the X account @vladimirputiniu, created in May 2022, [posted](#) a video accusing the British government of preparing the deployment of troops to Moldova and Ukraine. Between September 10 and 13, at least 16 X accounts posted two versions of the same content using the same video and picture, copy-pasting the text, in English and Polish language. The total X views of this part were more than 340,000. On September 18, the pro-Russian Polish online media “Mysl Polska” published an [article](#) claiming Romanian troops are ready for this military operation. On the same day, the Romanian-language Moldovan online media “Dimineata” [spread](#) the same information. Between [September 20](#) and [23](#) the Telegram channel The Islander reinforced this narrative. On September 22 a photo portraying French soldiers started circulating on X, first [published](#) by the account @SlavFreeSpirit, and was later [shared](#) on VK by the channel Tsargrad. Although it was only a delegation of defense attaches who conducted a fact-finding visit to a military unit in the Cahul garrison, as [confirmed](#) by the Moldovan Defense Ministry in a note, it was used to claim that French troops were being deployed to Moldova for the alleged invasion of Transnistria. This X content reached a total of over 126,000 views. Russia’s news agency TASS published an [article](#) and an “[expert opinion](#)” to push this narrative as well. Most of the publications were in English, but the same narrative was spread in Polish, Russian, Romanian, French. The goal of this campaign was likely to sow panic and polarize the society just before Moldova’s parliamentary elections to be held on September 28, as well as to portray NATO and Western countries as aggressive actors that would bring war to Moldova.

Systemic violation assessment

This incident may potentially harm the electoral process in Moldova and sow panic in the country for the fear of a war scenario.

The manipulation lies in both content and tactics used to amplify the false narrative:

- a. The articles and social media posts contain or amplify false information.
- b. The employed tactics are manipulative because they use bot or fake accounts for amplification, as well as impersonation of credible media outlets in different languages.

It could be potentially illegal in Moldova. A full legal review is required.

Narrative

Meta-narrative 1: Troops from NATO countries are ready to occupy Moldova and Ukraine

Sub-Narrative 1-1: Romanian troops are ready to be deployed to Moldova to "resolve the Transnistrian issue by force";

Sub-Narrative 1-2: British troops are ready to be sent to Moldova and Ukraine;

Sub-Narrative 1-3: French soldiers have been spotted in Moldova;

Sub-Narrative 1-4: NATO countries will take over Moldova by force if PAS loses elections.

Impact and Outcome

Reach: The campaign was spread across multiple social media platforms and news websites. In particular, a Moldovan and a Polish news outlets were involved, while on X the tweets reached a total of over 300,000 views, and via Telegram at least 174 posts received more than 1.2 million views.

Outcome: N/A

Key Objectives and Behaviours

Objective 1: [Cause harm T0140](#) - The campaign aims at harming the electoral process in Moldova and escalating tensions with the Transnistria region.

Objective 2: [Undermine T0135](#) - The goal is to undermine the political stability of Moldova by spreading false allegations and polarizing the society.

[Develop Inauthentic News Articles T0085.003](#) - The technique was used to publish news articles with false allegations.

[Trolls Amplify and Manipulate T0049.001](#) - Several X troll accounts were used to spread the message and the audiovisual material created for the campaign.

[Deceptively Edit Video \(Cheap Fakes\) T0087.002](#) - A video was edited using images of British forces and Maia Sandu.

[Polarise T0135.004](#) - The campaign attempted to polarise the Moldovan society between pro-Western or pro-Russian sides.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: N/A

Recommendations:

- Respective social media platforms to remove fake content and take down inauthentic accounts;
- Moldovan media and public authorities should debunk the allegations of imminent military operations;
- NATO, EU and national StratCom units from the countries allegedly involved should release statements or messages via their social media channels to deny the allegations about the imminent invasion in Transnistria and Moldova.

Report	Threat Actor	Authors	Platforms	FIMI assessment
N/A	Russia	Matteo Pugliese, Debunk.org	X, Telegram, websites	High Certainty